Lesson 36: Choosing Evidence and Working from Sources

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 4: Research and Evidence

Adapted from Reading, Writing, Research, and Reasoning: An Advanced ESL Text by Gabriel Winer and Elizabeth Wadell, ASCCC Open Educational Resources Initiative (CC BY-NC 4.0): 4.5 Choosing Appropriate Evidence; 4.6 Working from Sources.

In this lesson

You learn to choose the evidence that really supports your point, not just evidence about the same topic. You also learn to treat sources as a conversation ("They Say / I Say"): report what published writers say, check the context of their words, then add your own thinking. Every university paper needs evidence and the writer's own ideas to fit together like this.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Choose the evidence that supports a specific point most directly.
- Balance source ideas and your own ideas with the "They Say / I Say" approach.
- Use five strategies for combining sources in your own argument.
- Check the context of a quotation so that you do not misrepresent a source.
- Decide when to use a short quotation, a paraphrase or a summary.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
evidence	facts, findings, quotations or examples from sources that support a point	an interview study of California employers
point (claim)	the idea you want the reader to accept	Bilingual children of immigrants have an economic advantage as adults.
directly support	prove the exact point, not just talk about the same topic	Quotation 3 directly supports the point.
They Say / I Say	first report what others say, then respond with your own view	Vince reports …; I agree, but …
implications	the possible future results of a finding	warn about the future consequences of language loss
underlying	not obvious; under the surface	identify underlying areas of agreement

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
out of context	taken away from the words around it, so the meaning changes	quoting a view the author rejects
misrepresent	describe someone's ideas falsely	Inexperienced writers sometimes misrepresent their sources.
refute	show that an idea is wrong	The author goes on to refute it.
block quote	a long quotation set apart from your text, indented, without quotation marks	used only with a good reason

Rules and explanations

Evidence must support your exact point

Evidence about the same topic is not enough: it must be directly connected to your point. Ask:

- Does it address the exact claim (for example, an **economic** advantage **as adults**, not bilingualism in general)?
- Does it add something more specific, or does it only repeat your point?
- If it contains a statistic, is the statistic about your point? Numbers are tempting, but a number about something else is not evidence.
- Good evidence for one paragraph may be the wrong evidence for another.

Joining the conversation: They Say / I Say

A research paper joins a conversation that expert writers have already started. First you report what "they" say (published authors, common ideas in society, people in a public debate). Then you respond: do you agree, disagree, or a little of both? You may cite a finding as evidence for your point, or summarize an idea to show how your view differs or how the idea applies to a new situation.

Two mistakes to avoid

Mistake	The book's example
Your claims go beyond your sources.	Your research shows that children who keep their home language do better on cognitive tests, but you claim they also have higher high school graduation rates. The second claim needs its own evidence.
Only sources, no you.	The paper only quotes, summarizes and paraphrases. A research paper is not just a report: it is organized around your own thinking, supported by your research.

Five strategies for combining sources with your ideas

- a. Combine findings from several sources to make a larger summary argument.
- b. Combine findings from several sources to make a claim about their implications.
- c. Identify underlying areas of agreement.

- d. Identify underlying areas of disagreement.
- e. Identify unanswered questions.

The book's example for each strategy is in Exercise 3. When you cite sources you agree with, choose quotations or paraphrases that work as building blocks in your own argument.

Respect the context

Writers misrepresent sources when they quote a very minor point, something mentioned in passing, or a position the author disagrees with. This often happens when you read sources only to find sentences that match your own opinion. Before you quote, read the whole paragraph and ask: is this the author's own view?

Use sources efficiently

- You can quote or paraphrase whole sentences or just phrases. Most quotations should be short: key terms, phrases, parts of sentences or single sentences.
- A long passage of more than one sentence can be a **block quote**: indented, with no quotation marks. (More exactly: MLA uses a block quote only for more than four lines of prose, APA for 40 words or more.) A long quotation needs a good reason to be there.
- Every part of a quotation should feel necessary. Many long quotations usually mean that your own argument is undeveloped.
- A good college research paper typically includes few direct quotations. Paraphrasing is harder, and quoting can feel safer, but a paraphrase usually fits most smoothly into your writing.

> **Psychology note:** Psychology papers use APA style. Writers paraphrase most source material, and an in-text citation includes the year: (Callahan, 2015) instead of the book's MLA (Callahan).

Practice

Exercise 1. Choosing the best evidence. Read "Know more than one language? Don't give it up!" by Rebecca Callahan in your lesson material (4.5). You want to make this point:

Children of immigrants who continue to develop their fluency in their home languages while learning English have an economic advantage as adults.

Which quotation provides the best support? Say why each of the others is weaker.

1. "For all the research that supports childhood bilingualism, it is only recently that scholars have begun to understand bilingualism in adults' professional lives."
2. "Historically notorious for their English monolingualism, a recent Gallup poll reports that in this nation of immigrants, only one in four American adults now reports being conversationally proficient in another language."
3. "Not only are bilingual young adults more likely to graduate high school and go to college, they are also more likely to get the job when they interview. Even when being bilingual is not a requirement, an interview study of California employers shows that employers prefer to both hire and retain bilinguals."

4. "Research links bilingualism to greater intellectual focus, as well as a delay in the onset of dementia symptoms. Frequent use of multiple languages is also linked to development of greater empathy."

Exercise 2. More evidence. Quotation 3 is not the only good evidence in the article. Find two more sentences that support the same point at least as directly: they must be about jobs, job status or earnings. (Look under the headings "Bilingualism related to higher earning" and "Relationship between bilingualism and intelligence".)

Exercise 3. Five strategies. Match each plan (1-5) with a strategy (a-e) from the Rules section.

1. You review papers that explore various factors affecting language loss in order to warn about the future consequences for children and communities.
2. You review research about the effectiveness of dual-immersion and then argue for more in-depth research into why it is more successful for some student populations than for others.
3. You find statistics from your city about how many students speak which languages at home, and compare those findings to the bilingual language programs in your local school district.
4. You find that the controversies about the effectiveness of bilingual education result from focusing on different student populations that have different needs.
5. You compare various students' experiences of learning a language in order to make generalizations about its effects.

Exercise 4. Context. A writer who wants to argue that being bilingual is bad for you quotes this sentence from an article: "There were warnings that bilingual children would be confused by two languages, have lower intelligence, low self-esteem, behave in deviant ways, develop a split personality and even become schizophrenic." Read the whole paragraph in your lesson material (4.6, "Notice the context of the evidence in the original source").

1. Does the author of the article agree with these warnings?
2. Find three phrases in the paragraph that show her view.
3. What is wrong with using this quotation as evidence that bilingualism is harmful?

Exercise 5. Short quotation and paraphrase. Use quotation 3 from Exercise 1.

1. Choose a short part of it (a phrase or part of a sentence) and build it into a sentence of your own.
2. Paraphrase the whole quotation: change the words and the sentence structure, but keep the meaning exact.

Speak with your tutor

- "Here is the claim I want to make in my research paper: [claim]. Here are three quotations from my sources: [paste]. Which one supports my claim most directly? Why are the others weaker?"
- "Check my answers to Exercises 2 and 5. Is my paraphrase too close to the original? Is the meaning exact?"
- "Here is a quotation I want to use and the whole paragraph around it: [paste]. Is this the author's own view, or am I taking it out of context?"

- "Play the author of one of my sources: [name and main idea]. I will summarize what you say and then respond with my own view. Tell me if I represented you fairly."

Writing task

Your research project: evidence for one claim. Use your research question and annotated bibliography from Lessons 32 to 34. No project yet? Choose the book's topic (keeping a heritage language) or a psychology topic, such as sleep and memory in university students, or stress and coping among international students, and find two or three sources in Google Scholar, PubMed Central, ERIC, the Directory of Open Access Journals or the free OpenStax "Psychology 2e" textbook.

1. Write one claim (one sentence) that will be the point of a body paragraph in your paper.
2. Find three pieces of evidence for it in at least two of your sources. For each one, note the exact words (and page number, if there is one), the source, whether you will quote or paraphrase, and one sentence explaining how it supports your claim.
3. Check the context of each piece of evidence.
4. Write a paragraph of 150-200 words in They Say / I Say form: report what your sources say (at least one short quotation and one paraphrase, each with an in-text citation), then add your own response using one of the five strategies.

Self-editing checklist:

- Each piece of evidence supports my exact claim, not just my topic.
- Each one adds something more specific than my claim.
- Every statistic is directly about my claim.
- I am not quoting a view the author rejects or a point made only in passing.
- My quotations are short, and I paraphrase more than I quote.
- My claims do not go beyond what my sources show.
- My own thinking is clear, and I know which strategy I used.
- Every quotation and paraphrase has an in-text citation.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- The full article by Rebecca Callahan, "Know more than one language? Don't give it up!" (The Conversation): https://theconversation.com/know-more-than-one-language-dont-give-it-up-37573
- Gaia Vince, "Why Being Bilingual Helps Keep Your Brain Fit", quoted in 4.6 (the book's Mosaic link is dead; this is the same article, republished in a slightly adapted version): https://www.positive.news/science/bilingual-helps-keep-brain-fit/

Answer key

Exercise 1 (book)

- 3 is good evidence: it directly supports the point and adds something more specific than the point itself.
- 1: Its focus is on people doing research about bilingualism, not on the effects of bilingualism on careers.
- 2: It gives a fact about how many adults are monolingual, not about the results of keeping a second language. A statistic must relate directly to your point.
- 4: These are real advantages of bilingualism that you might use in another part of your paper, but none of them is about career success.

Exercise 2 (any two of these)

- "Currently, researchers . . . find that among children of immigrant parents, bilingual-biliterate young adults land in higher status jobs and earn more than their peers who have lost their home language." (the strongest: it is about children of immigrants, jobs and earnings)
- "Not only have these now-monolingual young adults lost the cognitive resources bilingualism provides, but they are less likely to be employed full-time, and earn less than their peers."
- "The ability to distinguish between oral proficiency . . . and actual literacy skills . . . has allowed researchers to identify an economic advantage to bilingualism – in terms of both higher occupational status and higher earnings in young adulthood."
- Also acceptable, but more general: "Research has now shown that bilingual young adults not only fare better in the job market, but are also more likely to demonstrate empathy and problem-solving skills."

Exercise 3 1 b · 2 e · 3 a · 4 d · 5 c

Exercise 4

1. No. She reports the warnings only to argue against them.
2. "It is a view that persisted until very recently" (an old view that discouraged immigrant parents); "in spite of a 1962 experiment, ignored for decades, which showed that bilingual children did better than monolinguals in both verbal and non-verbal intelligence tests"; "However, research in the last decade . . . is revealing a swathe of cognitive benefits for bilinguals."
3. The quotation is taken out of context and misrepresents the source: it presents an old view that the author refutes as if it were her evidence. A reader who knows the article will see that the writer is using evidence the source has already shown to be wrong.

Exercise 5 (example answers)

1. An interview study found that employers in California "prefer to both hire and retain bilinguals," even for jobs that do not require a second language (Callahan).
2. Rebecca Callahan, an associate professor of bilingual and bicultural education at the University of Texas at Austin, reports that young people who speak two languages finish high school and

continue to college more often than others, and they have a better chance of being offered a job after an interview. When researchers interviewed employers in California, the employers said they would rather hire and keep bilingual workers, even for positions that do not call for a second language.

My notes